Windows User & Group Management Guide

Comprehensive Administration: GUI (lusrmgr.msc) & PowerShell Automation

> **System Note:** `lusrmgr.msc` (Local Users and Groups) is built into Windows Pro, Enterprise, and Education editions. It is disabled in Windows Home. Administrators use this tool to manage machine-specific credentials, local group policies, and local rights.

1. EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW & TOOL ARCHITECTURE

Managing users in a Windows ecosystem operates at two distinct levels: **Local Machine Scope** and **Domain (Active Directory) Scope**. Understanding the boundary between local security accounts and network identities is critical for proper access control and administrative escalation.



2. CORE OPERATIONS IN LUSRMGR.MSC

To launch the console, press `Win + R`, type `lusrmgr.msc`, and hit **Enter**. The interface is split into two primary folders: **Users** and **Groups**.

👤 Account Management

- **Create User:** Right-click Users ➔ *New User...*
- **Reset Password:** Right-click account ➔ *Set Password...*
- **Disable/Enable:** Properties ➔ Toggle *Account is disabled*

🛡️ Group Management

- **Assign Role:** User Properties ➔ *Member Of* ➔ Add
- **Create Group:** Right-click Groups ➔ *New Group...*
- **Audit Privileges:** Double-click group to inspect members

3. ENTERPRISE USE CASES & DEPLOYMENT

While large organizations use Active Directory or Microsoft Entra ID for general user identities, `lusrmgr.msc` and local user configurations remain essential for specific IT operations:

DMZ & Standalone

Perimeter Servers

Isolated web servers or edge gateways in a DMZ that are intentionally disconnected from Active Directory to prevent domain compromise rely on local SAM accounts.

Imaging

Golden Image Staging

Desktop engineers configure offline local admin accounts during OS preparation (Sysprep/MDT) before deploying master disk images across fleet workstations.

Security

LAPS & Break-Glass

Integrated with Local Administrator Password Solution (LAPS) to ensure unique, rotating passwords for offline emergency recovery when domain controllers are unreachable.

Services

Local Service Accounts

Dedicated service identities for running background tasks, database engines, or backup scripts with restricted local rights.

4. BUILT-IN SECURITY GROUPS REFERENCE

Understanding default Windows local security groups is critical for granting minimum privilege access:

Group Name	Description	Recommended Usage
Administrators	Complete, unrestricted system access and privileges.	IT Helpdesk & System Admins only
Users	Standard users; prevented from making systemic changes.	Standard employees & workstations
Remote Desktop Users	Granted right to log in remotely via RDP protocol.	Telecommuters & Remote Staff
Backup Operators	Can override read/write permissions to back up files.	Backup service agents & software
Guests	Temporary access with automatic temporary profile cleanup.	Restricted public kiosk access

5. POWERSHELL AUTOMATION: LOCAL ACCOUNTS

PowerShell allows system administrators to automate local account management across hundreds of machines simultaneously without opening GUI consoles.

Creating and Configuring Local Accounts

```
# Prompt securely for new user password
$Password = Read-Host -AsSecureString

# Create a new local user account
New-LocalUser -Name "TechSupport" -Password $Password -FullName "Support Engineer" -Desc
ription "Tier 1 Helpdesk Account"

# Add the user to the local Administrators group
Add-LocalGroupMember -Group "Administrators" -Member "TechSupport"

# Ensure password never expires
Set-LocalUser -Name "TechSupport" -PasswordNeverExpires $true
```

Auditing and Maintenance Commands

```
# List all local user accounts
Get-LocalUser | Select-Name, Enabled, LastLogon

# Get members of a specific local group
Get-LocalGroupMember -Group "Remote Desktop Users"

# Disable and remove a local account
Disable-LocalUser -Name "TechSupport"
Remove-LocalUser -Name "TechSupport"
```

6. POWERSHELL VS. ACTIVE DIRECTORY MAPPING

Transitioning from local management to enterprise management involves mapping local cmdlets to Active Directory module equivalents:

Management Task	Local Machine Cmdlet	Active Directory Cmdlet
Get User Details	`Get-LocalUser`	`Get-ADUser`
Create Account	`New-LocalUser`	`New-ADUser`
Modify Password	`Set-LocalUser`	`Set-ADAccountPassword`
Group Assignment	`Add-LocalGroupMember`	`Add-ADGroupMember`
Account Unlock	`Enable-LocalUser`	`Unlock-ADAccount`